

Makerfield returns Burnham, and ends a premiership

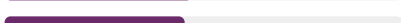
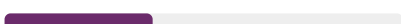
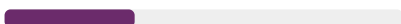
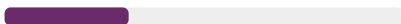
12 divisions 2,080 written questions 235 distinct askers

The safest of Labour seats changed hands on Thursday. By Monday morning it had taken a Prime Minister with it. Andy Burnham, Mayor of Greater Manchester and out of the Commons since 2017, won the Makerfield by-election with 54.8% of the vote. His majority was 9,241 over Reform UK. Turnout was the highest at a by-election since 2019. The seat had been vacated by Josh Simons expressly so that Burnham could stand. He was sworn in on Monday 22 June. That same morning, Sir Keir Starmer announced he would resign as Labour leader and Prime Minister. Burnham's return had brought months of pressure to a head. It is the seventh change of leader in a decade, set in motion by a single constituency a sitting government did not even lose. Around the earthquake, the Commons kept grinding. There were twelve divisions and an Armed Forces Bill pushed through report stage on the very day the leader fell. There were 2,080 written questions from 235 members, with women's pensions the subject that drew the most members in.

THE DIVISIONS, CLOSEST FIRST

National Security Bill, New Clause 3		144–244
National Security Bill, Amendment 8		143–249
National Security Bill, Amendment...		135–258
National Security Bill, Allocation of ...		233–94
Armed Forces Bill, New Clause 4		164–311
Armed Forces Bill, Amendment 11		171–322
Opposition Day, Puberty blockers		112–283
Opposition Day, Defence spendin...		294–110
Opposition Day, Defence spendin...		108–307
National Security Bill, Amendment 3		85–317
Armed Forces Bill, New Clause 22		74–323
Armed Forces Bill, New Clause 11		104–391

WRITTEN QUESTIONS, BY DEPARTMENT

Transport		269
Health		243
Defence		180
Home Office		160
Education		143
Housing		141
Treasury		131
Environment		127
Foreign Office		122
Work and Pensions		100
Business and Trade		88
Cabinet Office		83
12 others		293

THE MOST-ASKED SUBJECTS

10 Internet: Children 8 Tax Avoidance 7 Companies: Registration 7 Public Sector: Procurement
 7 Department for Work and Pensions: Women against State Pension Inequality 7 State Retirement Pensions: Women
 6 PE and Sport Premium 6 Domestic Abuse 6 Civil Servants: Workplace Pensions 6 Flood Re

A SAMPLE OF THE WEEK'S QUESTIONS

Special Advisers: By-elections · Mike Wood, Conservative

What information does the Cabinet Office special adviser HR function hold on whether any special advisers have been seconded or taken unpaid leave to undertake political activity in parliamentary by-elections since 1 January 2026?

THE ANSWER As per the Code of Conduct for Special Advisers, where a special adviser wishes to undertake work for a political party which does not arise out of government business they may do this either in their own time, outside office hours, or under a separate contract with the Party, working part-time for the Government. They may not use annual or unpaid leave for this purpose.

Domestic Abuse: Older People · Sonia Kumar, Labour

What steps is the Department taking with Cabinet colleagues to help support elderly domestic abuse victims?

THE ANSWER From April 2025, the Home Office has allocated nearly £800,000 to Hourglass to provide specialist helpline and advocacy support for older victims of VAWG. We will also publish a new national commissioning statement on VAWG to improve the provision of support for all victims, including older victims.

FEATURE

The seat that unseated a Prime Minister

The week's set-piece happened outside the Chamber. It played out at a count in Wigan, then at a lectern in Downing Street. Makerfield fell vacant in May when Josh Simons stood down to clear the way for Andy Burnham.